Baedoor Magic

This doc is written with the purpose of compiling all information on Baedoor magic, creating a resource that is both exhaustive and digestive for further brainstorming and working out details useful for future gameplay.

- Origins of magic
- Principles of design
- Lore outcomes
    - Destroyer gods
    - Spirits
    - The Void
    - Magic relationship with technology
- Categorising of magic elements
    - kinds
    - elements
    - shapes
- Categorising of magic
    - common magic (individual/inclusive)
    - paths (hermetic/sacrificially exclusive?)
    - schools (academic/categorising)
    - sealing
    - half-magic (connection, illusion, mind manipulation)
    - pure-magic (void)
    - chaos (self-evoked magic and phenomena beyond intentional)
        - probably magic as striking a balance between chaos and order? e.g. if you make a spell, it can be precise, but costly/less powerful, or you can balance it out by adding negative effects, which will enhance the spell effect
    - oneironautics
    - rituals

    - sigils
- Gameplay usage

Principles of design

It's important to emphasize that neither this document nor any magic planning should be overly *technical*. I don't mean this in a sense of explaining how particular paths work or how it would be implemented in a game - but rather that magic in itself shouldn't obey clear, designated rules. The focus should be on explaining its origins, how magic appears in the world, how it interacts with magic users and environment, but not putting restrictive rules that dictate themselves onto everything.
It's mostly a note to avoid the common pitfall of making magic that relies on an artificial rulebook and assigning itself into a very particular set of principles. These can have a place, but too many magic systems try to bind themselves to some sort of "system" that is crafted with great detail and explaining each intricacy as if it was science. Baedoor's magic is a mystery, slowly learned and with a lot of knowledge gaps. In this case, following IRL inspirations is for the best.

Gameplay usage

B3D's magic is meant to be shaped by three pillars-inspirations: **Morrowind**'s thoughtful difficulty that requires mages to prepare, **Noita**'s/**Arx Fatalis**' DIY character of customisation that rewards experimentation, and **lore**'s rigidness that both limits and expands on ways to work with magic compared to regular RPG experience.

Also note on **real magic** versus **fantasy magic** and its game representation: reading Kraig's description of rituals, I can sense that fantasy magic is not as nonsensical as it could be imagined at first with all its fireballs and flashy stuff.

Kraig's rituals are basically the same, with just the fact that all the flashy aspects are *imagined*, but they exist in almost very similar form otherwise. Therefore we can imagine that fireballs are a **representation** of what real magic would represent as real only on a mystical (imagined) sphere. Therefore these existing on a physical sphere can be seen as a symbol, or a game being a combination of both spheres.
What is more important, Arx Fatalis system also highlights the process of shaping the spell by proceeding ritual signs: it is something that I think should be a base for how spells could be created and/or evoked in B3D, as it ties the fantasy simplification/symbolism back with the real magic.
...it's also just much more fun, even though it can be frustrating mechanically because it kinda skips the simplicity of e.g. Morrowind or Noita "typical crafting" system.

Origins of magic

Magic is an energy originating from Void, which in itself is a trans-dimension yielding void energy: the purest form of what is known to be energy to all beings.
Magic is, in comparison, a sifted, limited form of void, a more dynamic and fluid and less destructive form of it. The lack of precision allows it to more easily be absorbed into various forms (vessels), but having its origins in void, it is its messenger and transmitter. Magic cannot ascend back to be void (let's say it's a lossy conversion) but it can bring the object of its effect to the void, which is why it can still be dangerous.

Magicians are ones who try to tame this energy, understand its dynamic, and focus it on particular objects and tasks. As the spellcasting is very much a work of a relation between that energy and magician, the process in itself relies heavily upon self-awareness and individual work.

Concepts

Vessels

Vessel in a magical sense is a term used for anything that contains empty space able to absorb magic, a sifted form of Void.
Most things in the universe are vessels in one way or another, but they can differ in many ways, meaning some of them will be much more fitting to be an object of magical practices or less so.

Each vessel is characterised by its resistance, a sort of protection or form that decides how easily a vessel absorbs magic. This depends on various traits of the vessel: most commonly material, but also spiritual power and will.

Material is the most basic and shared trait of all vessels - it does follow formal logic of physics, rendering organic materials as most vulnerable, and as the material hardens, so does the magic resistance. There are some caveats here, but the general rule persists.
Organic material however is usually equipped with additional defence mechanics, most importantly *soul*, or *spirit*, or *will*, a power emerging from a large enough vessel (empty space) capable of absorbing void.

The existence of vessels themselves comes from the concept that *everything in the beginning of time was Void*. For things to appear, Void needed to create an empty space, an absence of itself, and from that absence existence emerged.
Therefore anything that lives (be it living being or inanimate object) is a form of void's absence, and as such it holds that absence in itself - it's what a vessel is. The magic (a sifted form of void) is not a stable thing, therefore it can't transform a vessel back into pure Void, it is a vibrating and fluid aspect that can only fill the

vessel. The absorption of magic is, however, not a neutral thing, and can be dangerous - the fact that the void is sifted does not make it an immediate threat, but its void origins still remain and need to be handled carefully.

[...]

Ways of practice

Sigils

Sigils are symbolic representations of an item or thought that uses the principle of words being a conveyer of magic themselves. On a deeper psychological level, they signify the object, and are somewhat a "lossy" representation of its basic traits.
This makes them a great way to remind a magician about the larger and more complex idea invoked, thus becoming a tool for refocus. In context of Baedoor mechanics, this means that sigilling helps to put less time and magic energy while sealing the spell into the item, since the sigil itself holds partial responsibility to help with future unsealing. This changes emphasis from sealing method towards sigilling itself - unsuccessful reading of sigil may end up with unsealing itself to fail. The art of sigilling is therefore a skill that while tedious and limiting early on, can benefit long-term as the learning improves.

[ghloddish tradition, *not* that wide concept, but more common nowadays (see FotB trying to learn it)]

[...]

Mores

[mores as pattern-learning, unlike binding/unbinding]
[...]

Philosophy

A section used for more philosophic aspects that carry little weight for both lore and mechanics of Baedoor - but are interesting context to all matters discussed.

Notes

Nostalgic items

The possible reason people do feel nostalgic about certain items is that they put their memories in them - it is a simple and often unconscious magic, a lower form of binding. It is less bound to the item, but it makes a person resonate with the item through the magic put by themselves.

Equality

Generally speaking, everyone can use magic, but it's not equal - depending on circumstances, you can be really good or terrible, it's kinda a mixture of your biological and psychological conditions, beliefs and life experience.
Rules exist, but they are more imposed by specific movements instead of being hard requirements (experiments are common).

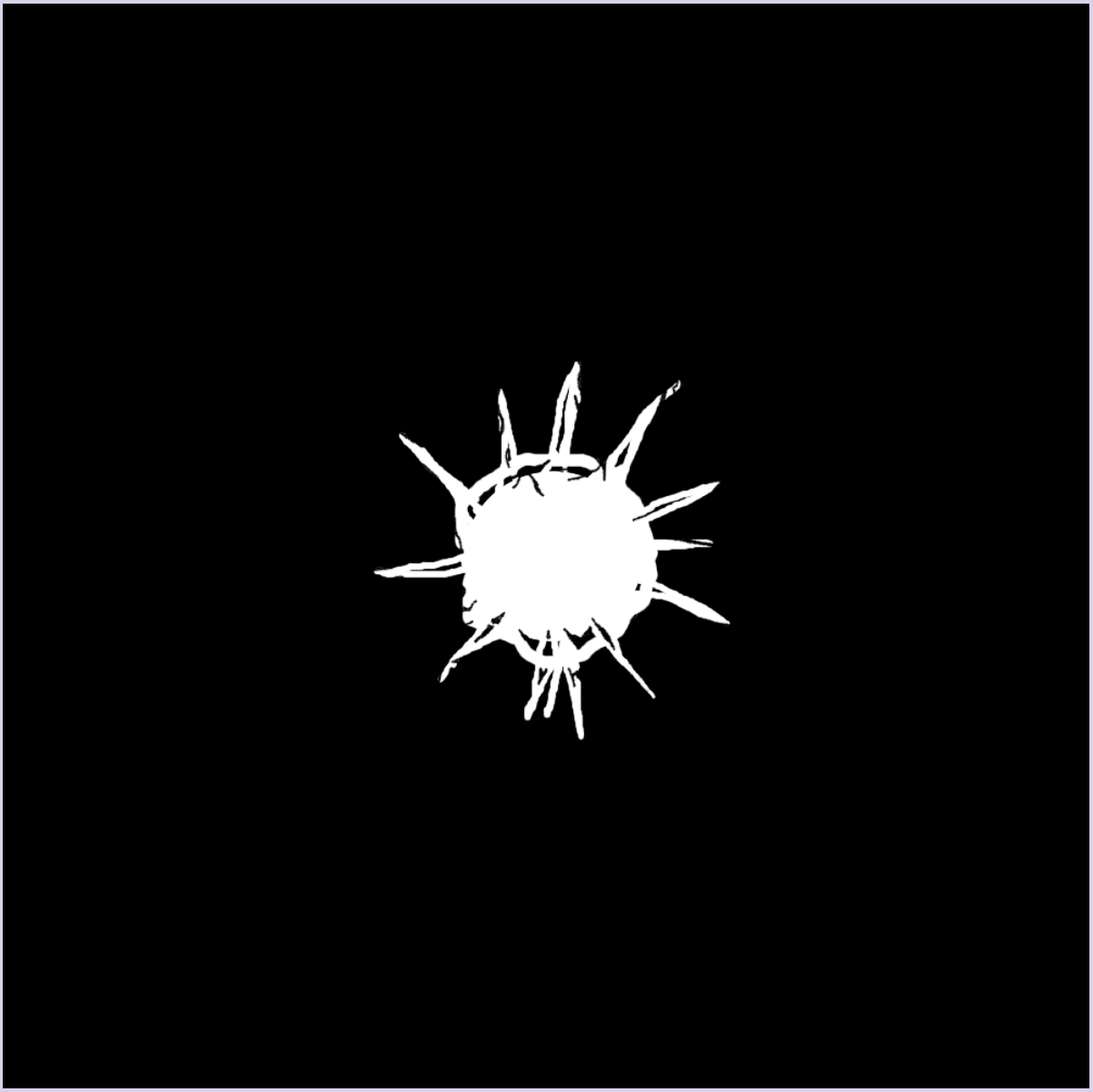
And since Void is the most powerful energy, the magic effects vary from the subtlest one to most destructive, e.g. tearing the continent in half (what happened to Moon Continent). Mind you though the effects depend on the user, and even gods have limits in what can they do. Normal mortal being is not likely to achieve anything crazy, albeit obviously magicians, scholars of magic and others try their best and achieved a lot throughout centuries of experimenting.

Void as a Force

The symbol of light being wisdom is kept, however the darkness is seen as another form of light; it follows very much the idea of void being a force.

Magic as filling the Void (Kaballah inspiration)

The idea behind magic as born from Void can have interesting outcomes in terms of what magic actually *is*. It can be seen as manipulating physics and laws (thus being opposite to technology, or interrupting it at least), but it can be also seen as a form of shaping the Void force into something controllable.
It can be also imagined (which isn't particularly conflicting here) as a way to fill the void. It is inspired by kabbalistic quote brought by Tokarczuk where "God had to step back, to let human came to existence - so He left the absence in where he was".
Magic could be seen as manipulating space in a way where you let the void in - which would explain both the danger, as well as power coming from it. The need of control and the difficulty of it is also somewhat bound to this idea.



Silly doodle that became more serious the further I got. A symbolic depiction of relationship between Void and World, and how they interact.
World stretches itself out, while Void consumes and carves into World. The magic is process of carving, bringing back Void to where it is absent, which is why the art of magic is seen as dangerous and chaotic/hard to control.
Which is what I meant by me being inspired by kaballah - World is the absence of Void, similarly how kabbalistic thought was that our IRL world is made out of absence of God. Religiously speaking.. I can imagine *faith* in this case is what would be IRL carving to bring God back.

The symbolic representation of the idea: **void** is the default "matter" or "existence", in which the **world** appeared, tearing void out to create void-absence for itself (or was it void that formed absence that did it? each option has interesting consequences). Thus:

- void can naturally want to drag world back into the void (*especially* if void-absence was forced, less so if void itself made/makes periodically such absences)
- magic is basically bringing limited portions of void back to the world, which is dangerous (it is letting its energy in from where it escaped, after all)

Also, if void absence exists because of void doing so, this can mean worlds sometimes spontaneously appear as an effect of this phenomenon.

...it also kinda reflects why living beings (or even static ones) would be able to have or absorb magic. Since the world is somewhat of a creation of void, all would have some sort of magic embedded in their physical form. Living beings could have it more fluid/controllable because of being, well, living; and statics could have a harder way to introduce magic in them exactly for that reason (they are not organic, thus the magic is less fluid if embedded).

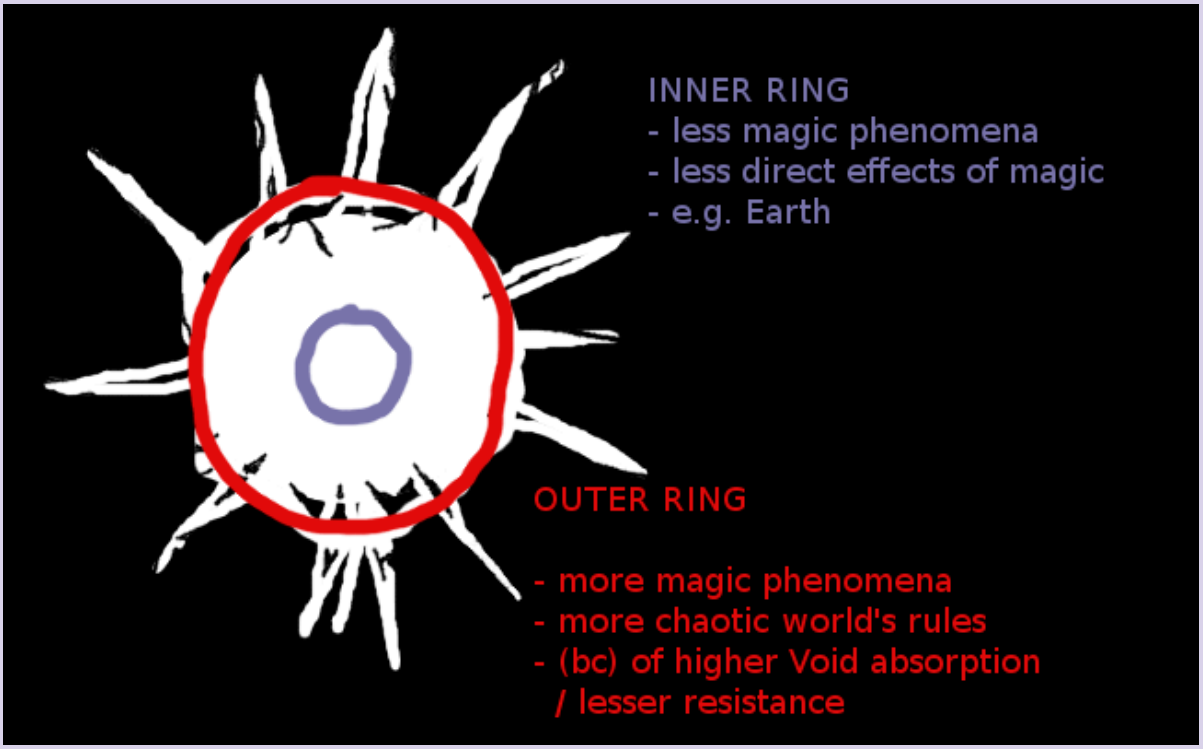
How much *magic* and *soul* would be the same or separate things is also interesting. I'd probably say that *soul*, if meant to be unique, could be what appeared because of lack of void. Void would in this case be the source of life, while soul would be the element of independence, the empty vessel.
Which explains why magic naturally goes into living beings (it fills the vessel) and regenerates over time (sleeping lets the vessel be filled - some oneironautic magic/oververse-void connection?); I imagine there could be some purists who would see this as bad thing and try to purify themselves out of magic (basically trying to stay at mana=0 as long as possible).
...this purifying system also kinda explains better TECH-MAGCK split, as both natural conflict of forces, but also conscious process of detachment from Void. And why people would consider TECH as

safer, as it is more deterministic (almost like... procedural vs AI programming, huh). Before we go too far with this though, mind you magic (in its typical sense of craft) is meant to be also deterministic, it just appears from chaotic force that just needs to be put into deterministic means.

Btw, "soul is an empty vessel into which void/magic drops" is literally "as above so below" for the idea of "world is an empty vessel into which void/magic seeps in".

Tehom Aranai's Rings of reality?

With idea of reality being inside Void, like on the CA above, it makes a lot of sense to portray multiverses/Oververse being in "rings" and "outer" rings being more magically charged make sense - they are closer to the Void, at least on the mental model (assuming there's no *actual* space, but rather something symbolically similar).



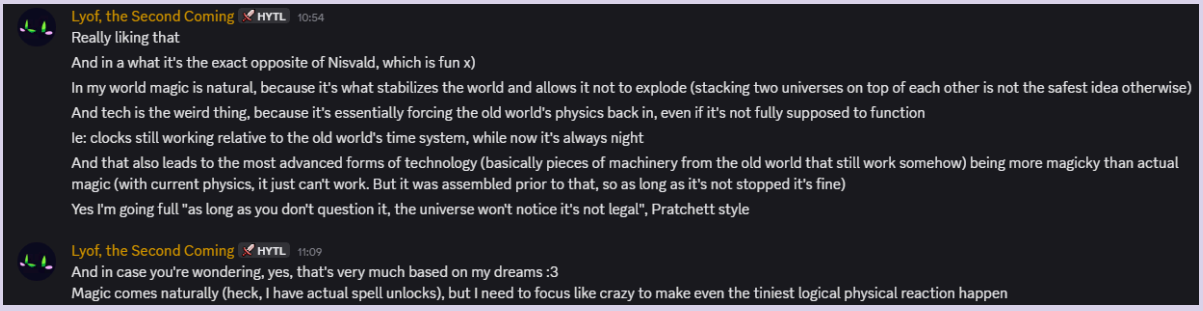
Other Brainstorming

"Life" as a product of void is interesting, because it kinda opposes this concept. If the world was created out of absence of void, life is also created in the absence of void (= vessel idea). Would void allow for reproducing absence, was my thought? Or would it be seen as making more vessels for the void to seep in, so would the void support creating life as sort of a bridge between the two realities? (this would somehow work with the idea of void cycling between autocreating absence-consuming absence back-creating absence-etc.)

Also, this idea of void/world would mean gods didn't create the world, but gods could create life. Which further reinforces that making beings alive *is* a form of magic, and one of higher ones, thus using void.

Other Brainstorming v2

If void creates worlds periodically, and sleep is when we connect to the void (regenerate mana), oneironautism naturally falls as a way to connect to other worlds. Be it as mere medium or more concrete way to actually experience/affect them.
By Lyof's/Xaine's Nisvald concept:



Dream magic could reverse the order of what stabilises the vision, and so logic (getting to absences (worlds)) would require much more actual effort and skill. Which is the main reason why oneironauts usually only see worlds - even that very loosely - and almost never can interact with them.

Travelling in this case would be as if you tried to carve the absence in what is dominated by void.

Other Brainstorming v3

A logical conclusion of all this is also that **thoughts** and **feelings** are a domain of void, a sort of carving of it in our souls/bodies. Since thoughts can - by logic of cosmology/oververse - create new universes, they are tiniest forms of magic available to any living being. Feelings in this train of thought is simply a continuation, because they are somewhat similarly affective, and often connect to thoughts on an even deeper level.
If this would work that way, **art** is then a void carving into societal structure and culture as a whole. It is a way for spiritual connection, which it actually is considered as IRL, and also a way to transmit thoughts/feelings between people. It's a sort of indirect magic done on people. That's why ghloddish culture considers text as magic (again kabbalah inspiration here) because good writing or imagery can evolve into movements, they are somewhat like a ritual evoking a faith (or.. ideology). All the cool leftist analysis comes into play here, and of course all the esoteric thought that touches similar connections.
...it also adds an interesting layer that non-alive items, while harder to enchant, can be rather turned into art, which is like a different form of magic possessing the item.

Main thoughts either way:

- training art or philosophy or logic is partially a magic training, and certainly would be part of actual magic faculties (as sort of muscle training before you learn spells)
- restraining feelings is sort of the process of magic - turning chaos into order, limiting what is extreme into what is narrow and more understandable

- an idea of "hand of a writer" being able to turn words into worlds, from my "Brother Story" and Myst worldbuilding, makes much more sense here
- to keep the balance tight, it should be understood how much thought-making of universes works - it shouldn't be something on the whim or controlled, it would rather be void gracefully opening the space for the absence to arrive (in hope of creating new flux?) as a result of its flow
    - Void shouldn't be considered as entity, and less so as "consuming without thought", it doesn't actually try to destroy the absence: it rather goes into infinite dance, letting itself and absence emerge in smoothest play, without particular logic or rules (and also *intentions*, because I feel like I'm a bit anthropomorphising it in my writing)

Void Contemplation

A process of drawing forms that indicate void/world relationship, which can take any form (example of circular form above).

Questions:

★ what are gods?
★ what are spirits in this understanding of the world?
★ what are tertens, considering the above questions + all the rest

Also further implications:

- if organic-ness / living means the item is better for magic, the best scrolls would be made out of paper made from plants
- and plants themselves would be good to put magic in... magic traps hidden inside plants?
- plants would be the mixture of living and non-living; I imagine they wouldn't have vessel, but would be easier to push magic into

- wood in that sense could also work as a somewhat friendliest form of solid item, meaning staffs *would* have some sense, similarly wooden tablets/boards would be the best mores. Bone mores would follow the same logic, less so would stone mores mentioned in B3D Doc. And paper being most destructible yet also most absorbable also would get additional sense.

Magic	Technology
Working by itself or reshaping world's rules temporarily	Working with rules of the world
Safety depending on scope (amount of void affects instability of the spell/destructive effects)	Relatively safe (deterministic)
Less or more elitist (somewhat higher barrier entry for simple tasks, much higher for anything complex)	Egalitarian (in sense of low barrier entry for use)
Builds on internal magic energy and understanding how it can shape the world around	Builds on materials

Pulsating Energy?





Bonding

From BE's notes:
Enchanting items is difficult, as it requires scroll-like unbounding, so wearer/user should be both good at dodging-and-magic, fighting-and-magic,
so it's really obscure choice and rather unliked by requirements it sets.
Additionally, it requires really good timing, as it needs unbounding at
the second of hitting the enemy.
Enchanting gear is actually easier than using said gear.

This is why rods are used to TRANSFER energy into spell, not as something
adjecent to the rod itself - hitting someone with rod is extremely weak
and would be tough to work with. Transfering, in the other hand, means
that you have three steps:

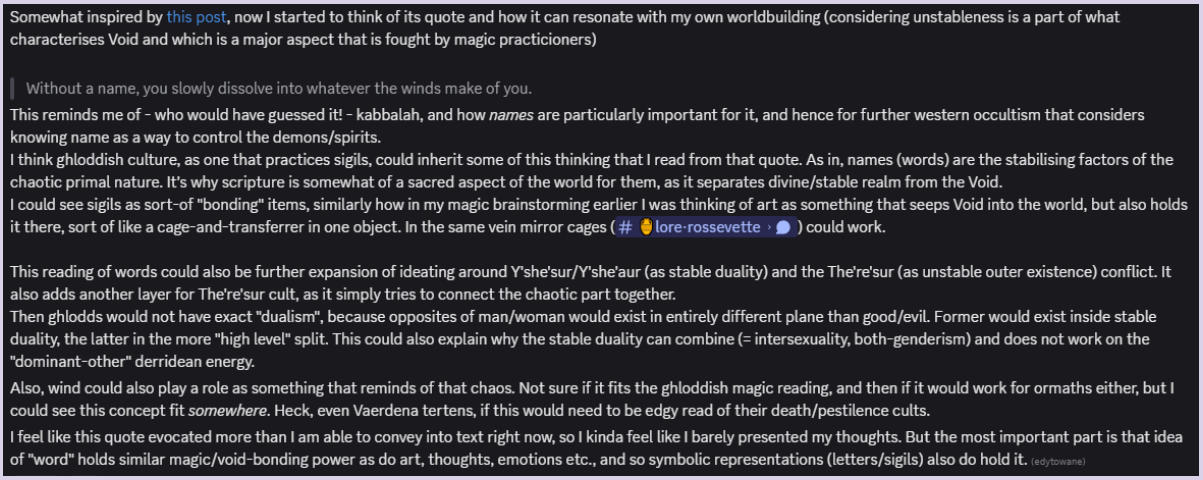
CAST SPELL TO YOU ---> CAST INTO ROD

---> UNBOUND AND CAST INTO TARGET

It may come in handy, to some extent, though it lenghtens the process
a lot

It also explains why mages wear enchanted robes instead of armour - it is
easier to unbound enchant from such light material than it is from more
solid thing

Ghloddish Magic


Somewhat inspired by this post, now I started to think of its quote and how it can resonate with my own worldbuilding (considering unstableness is a part of what characterises Void and which is a major aspect that is fought by magic practicioners)

> Without a name, you slowly dissolve into whatever the winds make of you.

This reminds me of - who would have guessed it! - kabbalah, and how *names* are particularly important for it, and hence for further western occultism that considers knowing name as a way to control the demons/spirits.
I think ghloddish culture, as one that practices sigils, could inherit some of this thinking that I read from that quote. As in, names (words) are the stabilising factors of the chaotic primal nature. It's why scripture is somewhat of a sacred aspect of the world for them, as it separates divine/stable realm from the Void.
I could see sigils as sort-of "bonding" items, similarly how in my magic brainstorming earlier I was thinking of art as something that seeps Void into the world, but also holds it there, sort of like a cage-and-transferrer in one object. In the same vein mirror cages (# lore-rossevette) could work.

This reading of words could also be further expansion of ideating around Y'she'sur/Y'she'aur (as stable duality) and the The're'sur (as unstable outer existence) conflict. It also adds another layer for The're'sur cult, as it simply tries to connect the chaotic part together.
Then ghlodds would not have exact "dualism", because opposites of man/woman would exist in entirely different plane than good/evil. Former would exist inside stable duality, the latter in the more "high level" split. This could also explain why the stable duality can combine (= intersexuality, both-genderism) and does not work on the "dominant-other" derridean energy.
Also, wind could also play a role as something that reminds of that chaos. Not sure if it fits the ghloddish magic reading, and then if it would work for ormaths either, but I could see this concept fit *somewhere*. Heck, even Vaerdena tertens, if this would need to be edgy read of their death/pestilence cults.
I feel like this quote evocated more than I am able to convey into text right now, so I kinda feel like I barely presented my thoughts. But the most important part is that idea of "word" holds similar magic/void-bonding power as do art, thoughts, emotions etc., and so symbolic representations (letters/sigils) also do hold it. (edytowane)

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